

INVENTORY • STACK • STRUCTURE

cards-stack

Parallel items stacked vertically, full-width cards.

Three forces are compressing the differentiation window.

Infrastructure has commoditized.

The platform work that took us two years is now a managed service a competitor can switch on in an afternoon. The moat is no longer the stack.

Release cycles have collapsed.

What used to ship annually now ships monthly. A visible advantage is matched before the next board meeting.

Switching costs are rising.

Customers consolidate vendors and sign longer contracts. The window to win an account is shorter, and losing one lasts longer.

Three patterns, each with its own pull.

Inventory.

Equal-weight items the audience scans without ordering. The cards-grid family lives here — grid, stack, wide, side.

Comparison.

Two or more items weighed against shared criteria. The verdict and compare families live here — they take sides.

Progression.

Items that carry an explicit sequence. The list-steps and timeline families live here — order is load-bearing.

Three reasons to keep cards-stack at three items.

1

Cognitive load

Three is the threshold the audience can hold without effort. Past three, the slide demands working memory the room shouldn't have to spend.

2

Vertical real estate

Each stacked card needs ~30% of the slide height to breathe. Four cards force you to shrink the cards until they stop reading as cards.

3

Build path symmetry

cards-stack pairs with cards-grid (3-4 items) for at-a-glance comparison. One stack layout, not two, keeps the family's choices clean.

Four workstreams, each with a current status pill.

Signal intake

shipped

Connector v1 and multi-source dedupe are live across all three regions. Anomaly auto-routing lands next sprint.

Scoring model

in review

The equal-weights baseline is calibrated; per-team weighting is in security review before the pilot opens.

Retrospective loop

at risk

Outcome classification is still too coarse to score reliably. The owner is reworking the rubric this week.

Rollout

not started

Gated on the scoring model clearing review, then sequenced for the following quarter.

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When NOT to reach for cards-stack.

Five or more items.

A fourth card fits with the **compact** modifier; past four the stack overflows. For five or more parallel items reach for cards-grid four, or split across slides.

One-line cards. If each card is a single short phrase, the stack reads as a padded list. Drop to **list** (or **takeaway** variant) and reclaim the vertical space.

Forced sequence. Cards-stack is parallel content read in vertical order, not a numbered sequence. For explicit steps, use list-steps or list-criteria.

RELATED COMPONENTS

See also.

`cards-grid` — three or four parallel items in a scannable grid

`compare-prose` — exactly two items, side by side

`list-steps` — items carry an explicit, ordered sequence